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The CA Foundation & Intermediate January 2027 Starter Handbook

The complete guide to India's Chartered Accountancy course under the 2023 scheme — every official date, paper, fee and rule for the 2–12 January 2027 exams, plus an 8-week study plan, subject playbooks, real pass data and the full journey from Foundation to membership.

JANUARY 2027 EDITION

Every fact verified from ICAI official announcements, FAQs and press releases · October 2026

About this handbook

Chartered Accountancy is the most respected professional qualification in Indian commerce, and the January 2027 attempt is a clean, well-documented entry point into it. This handbook exists to save you the weeks of scattered reading it usually takes to understand the course — because ICAI's rules are spread across announcements, FAQ PDFs and press releases, and much of what circulates on coaching channels is out of date since the New Scheme of Education and Training took effect on 1 July 2023.

Everything here is drawn from ICAI's own material: the 24 September 2026 examination announcement (No. 13-CA (EXAM)/JANUARY/2027), the Board of Studies FAQs on the New Scheme, the Self-Paced Online Modules FAQ, the official exam guidance notes, and ICAI's result press releases for the January and May 2026 sessions. Where a number, date or fee appears, it is an official one. Nothing is guessed.

Who this is for

- **Class 12 students and school-leavers** deciding whether and how to start CA — the Foundation route is the front door.
- **Foundation-registered students** appearing in the January 2027 exam and needing the exact dates, pattern and rules.
- **Intermediate students** sitting Group I, Group II or both groups in January 2027, including direct-entry graduates.
- **Parents and first-generation aspirants** who want one honest, complete map of the road ahead.

What is inside

- The full CA roadmap under the 2023 scheme — Foundation, Intermediate, Practical Training, Self-Paced Online Modules and Final.
- The January 2027 exam cycle decoded: official dates and timings, the 3–16 November registration window, every fee, 207 exam cities, and the eligibility cut-offs.
- A step-by-step walkthrough of the registration and exam-form process on ICAI's Self Service Portal.
- Foundation in full — registration, the four papers with their real syllabus, exam pattern, negative marking and the exact pass rule.
- Intermediate in full — both routes in, all six papers, the 30% MCQ pattern, the pass rule and how exemptions actually work.
- An attempt-strategy chapter: whether to take one group or both, decided with the real pass data.
- The journey after Intermediate — ICITSS, two years of articleship, the four Self-Paced Online Modules, the Final, and the BAA exit route.
- What the whole course costs, and how to use ICAI's own study material (SM, RTP, MTP and past papers) properly.
- Real competition data from the 2026 sessions, an 8-week preparation plan, subject playbooks and an exam-day playbook.
- A myth-versus-reality chapter, an FAQ, a quick-reference card, a final checklist and the official links you will actually need.

A note on accuracy and independence

This handbook is an independent study aid published by digitalkartai.shop. It is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or connected to the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI).

ICAI can revise dates, fees and rules. Before you act on any figure here — especially a deadline or a fee — confirm it at icai.org or eservices.icai.org. The January 2027 facts in this edition were verified in October 2026.

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Each part opens with its main point, then the detail. Tables carry the comparable facts; the prose carries the reasoning. Skim the tables first if you are short on time.

Part 1 · The CA profession and the 2023 scheme

A Chartered Accountant is a licensed financial professional — the person who audits companies, certifies accounts, files and defends tax positions, and advises businesses on money. In India the licence is granted by ICAI, a statutory body set up by an Act of Parliament. The route to it is a staged course, not a single exam, and since 1 July 2023 that course runs on the New Scheme of Education and Training.

The word “staged” matters. Each level unlocks the next, and between the levels sit compulsory training components that have nothing to do with exams but everything to do with eligibility. A student who clears every paper but skips a course or a training period still cannot reach the Final. So the first thing to internalise is the sequence, not any single exam.

The three levels, and what sits between them

Under the current scheme the course has three examination levels — **Foundation**, **Intermediate** and **Final** — plus four **Self-Paced Online Modules** and two years of practical training. You cannot simply sit the Final; you must clear each level, complete a four-week IT and soft-skills course, serve two years as an articled assistant, clear a second four-week course, and pass all four online modules before the Final examination is even open to you.

Stage	What you must do	When
Foundation	Register after Class 10; appear after Class 12. Clear 4 papers.	Exams 3 times a year
Intermediate	Register via the Foundation route or Direct Entry route; clear 6 papers in 2 groups.	Exams 3 times a year
ICITSS	Complete the 4-week Integrated Course on IT and Soft Skills (OC + ITT).	Before articleship
Practical Training	Serve 2 years as an articled assistant under a practising CA.	After both Inter groups
Self-Paced Modules	Qualify SET A, SET B and one elective each from SET C and SET D.	After registering for Final
Advanced ICITSS	Complete the 4-week Advanced course (MCS + Advanced ITT).	After articleship, before Final
Final	Clear 6 papers in 2 groups.	Exams held twice a year
Membership	Apply to ICAI; you become a Chartered Accountant.	After clearing Final

What changed in 2023, in one table

If you read older guides, you will meet terms like CPT, IPCC, PCC and a three-year articleship. Those belong to the old scheme. Here is the honest old-versus-new comparison, because knowing it stops you buying the wrong study material.

Feature	Old scheme	Current scheme (from 1 July 2023)
Entry exam	CPT	Foundation (4 papers)
Second level	IPCC / PCC	Intermediate (6 papers in 2 groups)
Practical training	3 years	2 years
Extra learning	GMCS / ITT courses	Self-Paced Online Modules (SET A–D)

Feature	Old scheme	Current scheme (from 1 July 2023)
Exam frequency	Twice a year	Foundation & Intermediate: 3 times a year; Final: twice a year
Exit credential	None	Business Accounting Associate (BAA)

Why the three-attempts-a-year change matters

ICAI now conducts the Foundation and Intermediate exams three times a year — in January, May and September. This is the single most useful structural fact for a new student: a failed paper no longer costs you six months. It costs you about four. That changes the whole strategy — you can afford to attempt with genuine preparation rather than panic, and you can spread groups instead of over-loading one sitting.

The one-line answer for a beginner

You do not need to master everything at once. Register early, clear Foundation, then take Intermediate one group at a time if you need to. The three-attempt cycle is designed to let you do exactly that.

What a Chartered Accountant actually does

It helps to know what the qualification is for, because it explains why the course is structured the way it is. A CA's work sits in five broad areas:

- **Audit and assurance** — examining a company's financial statements and expressing an independent opinion on them. This is the licence's core privilege: only a member may sign an audit report.
- **Taxation** — income-tax and GST compliance, return filing, planning, and representing clients before tax authorities.
- **Advisory** — business structuring, transactions, valuation, due diligence and financial consulting.
- **Certification and attestation** — signing the certificates and attestations that law requires for loans, tenders, filings and more.
- **Accounting and controllership** — running the finance function inside a business.

The practical training and the ethics components exist because a CA is trusted with other people's money and with the accuracy of public financial information. The exams test knowledge; the training and the modules test whether you can be relied on. Both are part of the qualification.

Part 2 · The January 2027 exam cycle, decoded

ICAI announced the January 2027 Foundation and Intermediate schedule on 24 September 2026. The exam runs from 2 to 12 January 2027, the online exam form window opens on 3 November 2026, and it closes without a late fee on 16 November 2026. Those three facts — the dates, the window and the fees — are the ones people get wrong. This part sets all of them out precisely.

Official examination dates and timings

All papers are held in the afternoon. Everything is a three-hour paper except Foundation Papers 3 and 4, which are two hours. A 15-minute advance reading time is given for every paper except those two.

Level / Group	Papers	Dates (2027)	Time (IST)
Foundation	Paper 1 · Paper 2	3, 5 January	2:00–5:00 PM (3 hrs)
Foundation	Paper 3 · Paper 4	7, 9 January	2:00–4:00 PM (2 hrs)
Intermediate Group I	Papers 1–3	2, 4, 6 January	2:00–5:00 PM (3 hrs)
Intermediate Group II	Papers 4–6	8, 10, 12 January	2:00–5:00 PM (3 hrs)

Read the sequence carefully — it tells you the order in which you must be ready. A Foundation candidate sits Accounting first (3 Jan) and Business Economics last (9 Jan). An Intermediate candidate taking both groups starts with Advanced Accounting (2 Jan) and finishes with Financial Management & Strategic Management (12 Jan).

The registration window — do not miss this

Registration in the course and filling the exam form are two separate steps. You must already be registered in the course (with the study-period condition met) before the exam form opens. The form window for January 2027 is:

Event	Date
Online exam form opens	3 November 2026 (Tuesday)
Last date without late fee	16 November 2026 (Monday)
Last date with late fee (Rs. 600 / US$ 10)	19 November 2026 (Thursday)
Correction window (city, medium, group, centre)	20–22 November 2026

Eligibility cut-offs for this attempt

Two dates decide who may sit the January 2027 exam, and they come from the study-period rules:

- **Foundation:** you must have registered for the Foundation course on or before **1 September 2026** (a four-month study period before the exam month), and you must have appeared in your Class 12 board examination.
- **Intermediate:** you must have registered for the Intermediate course on or before **1 May 2026** (an eight-month study period), whether through the Foundation route or the Direct Entry route.

If you registered after those dates, you are not shut out — you simply target the May 2027 attempt. The registration clock, not the exam date, is what you plan around.

Fees for January 2027

Examination	Indian centres	Kathmandu	Other overseas
Foundation	Rs. 1,500	Rs. 2,200	US$ 325
Intermediate — one group / Unit	Rs. 1,500	Rs. 2,200	US$ 325
Intermediate — both groups	Rs. 2,700	Rs. 3,400	US$ 500

Fees are paid online only, through the Self Service Portal at eservices.icai.org, by card (Visa / Mastercard / Maestro / RuPay), net banking or UPI. Note the distinction between the one-time **course registration fee** (Foundation Rs. 9,000; Intermediate Rs. 18,000) and this **per-attempt exam fee**. They are different payments at different times.

Where the exam is held, and in what medium

The January 2027 exams are held across **207 cities in India**, plus three overseas centres: Bahrain, Dubai (UAE) and Kathmandu (Nepal). The city list runs to every state and union territory, from Port Blair and Guwahati to Kochi, Rajkot and Bhubaneswar. Overseas, Dubai starts at 12:30 PM local (equivalent to 2:00 PM IST), Bahrain at 11:30 AM local, and Kathmandu at 2:15 PM local.

Foundation and Intermediate candidates may answer in **English or Hindi**. You choose the medium when you fill the exam form, and it can be changed only during the 20–22 November correction window. One practical point: for Foundation Papers 3 and 4 the OMR answer sheets are in English medium only, so even a Hindi-medium candidate fills an English OMR sheet.

The three mistakes that cost this attempt

Missing the 16 November deadline. There is no form-filling after 19 November even with the late fee. Put a reminder for the first week of November.

Assuming the old date cycle. Foundation and Intermediate no longer run only in May and November — January, May and September are the cycles now.

Confusing registration with the exam form. If your course registration misses the 1 September (Foundation) or 1 May (Intermediate) cut-off, you cannot sit this attempt regardless of when you pay the exam fee.

Part 3 · Registering and filling the exam form

Almost every January-attempt problem reported by students is administrative, not academic — a lapsed registration, an unuploaded mark-sheet, a missed window. This part walks the whole process from login to admit card so you can clear it early and forget it.

The eight steps

1. **Get your SSP login working.** Everything happens on ICAI's Self Service Portal at eservices.icai.org. Your username is your student registration number in the form SRN@icai.org. If you have never logged in, use the forgot-password option; if your photo or signature is missing or poor quality, upload fresh ones now.
2. **Confirm your course registration is valid.** Check that your Foundation or Intermediate registration is active and not lapsed. If it has lapsed, revalidate it on the portal before the exam-form window opens — you cannot fill the form on a lapsed registration.
3. **Meet the study-period cut-off.** Foundation needs registration by 1 September 2026; Intermediate by 1 May 2026. Verify your registration date against your eligibility on the portal.
4. **Upload your Class 12 proof (Foundation candidates).** Upload your Class 12 mark-sheet, or the admit card if you are appearing provisionally. Provisional candidates must upload the required document by the deadline ICAI sets, or the admit card will not be issued.
5. **Wait for the exam-form window.** It opens on 3 November 2026. Do not wait for the last day — payment failures near the deadline are common and stressful.
6. **Fill the form and pay.** Choose your medium (English or Hindi), your exam city and the group(s) or papers you are attempting. Pay the fee online. Check that the transaction succeeded.
7. **Generate and save the barcoded form.** After a successful payment the portal generates a barcoded exam application PDF. Download it and keep a copy. Do not send a hard copy to ICAI — that is not required.
8. **Use the correction window if needed.** Between 20 and 22 November 2026 you can change your exam city, medium, group or centre. After it closes, no change is entertained.

Then the admit card

Admit cards are hosted on eservices.icai.org, generally about 14 days before the examination. No physical admit card is posted to anyone — you print it yourself. Check the details on it (name, registration number, centre, medium) as soon as it appears, and contact the ICAI exam helpline immediately if anything is wrong.

The traps, gathered in one place

- A lapsed course registration — revalidate before you try to fill the form.
- Missing or poor-quality photo and signature on SSP — fix them early.
- An unuploaded Class 12 mark-sheet (Foundation) — the single most common reason an admit card is withheld.
- Paying on the last day and hitting a transaction failure — leave at least a week of buffer.
- Not saving the barcoded exam form PDF — keep it at least until the admit card is out.

Help lines worth saving

SSP login / password / OTP issues: ssp.helpdesk@icai.in, or 99975 99975.

Foundation exam-form and admit-card queries: foundation_examhelpline@icai.in.

Fee-refund and failed-transaction queries: edpexam@icai.in.

Part 4 · Foundation — the entry gate

Foundation is where the CA course begins. You may register for it after passing Class 10, but you cannot sit the exam until you have appeared in your Class 12 board examination and completed a four-month study period. It is a 400-mark, four-paper examination: two descriptive papers and two objective papers.

Registration and validity

Item	Foundation
When you may register	After passing Class 10
When you may appear	After appearing in Class 12 + a 4-month study period
Registration fee	Rs. 9,000 (includes prospectus and study material)
Registration validity	4 years from the first eligible attempt
Revalidation	Not permitted at Foundation level
Exams held	Three times a year (January, May, September)

Registration is done through the Self Service Portal at eservices.icai.org. After registration you receive login credentials to order study material through ICAI's Centralized Distribution System. The study material itself is free on the BoS Knowledge Portal; you only pay if you want physical books.

The four Foundation papers and their syllabus

This is the official 2023-scheme syllabus, paper by paper. Each paper is 100 marks.

Paper 1 · Accounting (100 marks, descriptive)

Objective: to build a working understanding of accounting principles and the ability to prepare financial statements and solve problems. The syllabus runs through:

- **Theoretical framework** — meaning and scope of accounting; concepts, principles and conventions; capital vs revenue; accounting policies; accounting standards.
- **Accounting process** — double-entry, journal, subsidiary books, cash book, ledger, trial balance, rectification of errors.
- **Bank Reconciliation Statement**; **Inventories**; **Depreciation and amortisation**; **Bills of exchange and promissory notes**.
- **Final accounts of sole proprietors** — trading and P&L; account, balance sheet; and **financial statements of not-for-profit organisations**.
- **Accounts from incomplete records**.
- **Partnership and LLP accounts** — admission, retirement, death, goodwill, dissolution.
- **Company accounts** — shares and debentures, issue and forfeiture, redemption of preference shares and debentures, bonus and right issues.

Paper 2 · Business Laws (100 marks, descriptive)

Objective: general legal knowledge of contract, sale and business forms. The syllabus covers:

- **Indian Regulatory Framework** — the major regulators (Ministry of Finance, MCA, SEBI, RBI, IBBI and others).

- **The Indian Contract Act, 1872** — nature of contracts, consideration, essentials, performance, breach, contingent and quasi contracts, indemnity and guarantee, bailment and pledge, agency.
- **The Sale of Goods Act, 1930**; **The Indian Partnership Act, 1932**; **The LLP Act, 2008**.
- **The Companies Act, 2013** — features of a company, corporate veil, classes of companies, share capital, incorporation, MOA and AOA, doctrine of indoor management.
- **The Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881** — meaning, characteristics, classification, negotiation and presentment.

Paper 3 · Quantitative Aptitude (100 marks, objective)

Split three ways — Business Mathematics 40 marks, Logical Reasoning 20 marks, Statistics 40 marks:

- **Business Mathematics** — ratio and proportion, indices and logarithms; equations; linear inequalities; mathematics of finance (interest, present and future value, annuities, EMI, CAGR); permutations and combinations; sequence and series; sets, relations and functions, limits and continuity; basic differential and integral calculus.
- **Logical Reasoning** — number series, coding-decoding and odd-man-out; direction tests; seating arrangements; blood relations.
- **Statistics** — statistical representation of data and sampling; measures of central tendency and dispersion; probability; theoretical distributions (binomial, Poisson, normal); correlation and regression; index numbers.

Paper 4 · Business Economics (100 marks, objective)

- Introduction to business economics; basic problems of an economy and the price mechanism.
- Theory of demand and supply — elasticity, consumer behaviour, supply, market equilibrium.
- Theory of production and cost; price determination in different markets (perfect competition, monopoly, monopolistic competition, oligopoly).
- Business cycles; determination of national income.
- Public finance; money market and monetary policy; international trade and exchange rates.
- The Indian economy — a basic historical and current overview.

Exam pattern, marking and the pass rule

- **Papers 1 and 2** are descriptive (subjective), three hours each.
- **Papers 3 and 4** are objective (MCQ), two hours each, answered on OMR sheets that are English medium only.
- **Negative marking:** yes — 0.25 mark is deducted for every wrong answer in the objective papers. This is a Foundation-only feature; Intermediate and Final have no negative marking.
- **Pass rule:** you pass Foundation only if, at one sitting, you score a minimum of **40% in each paper** and a minimum of **50% in the aggregate** of all four papers.
- **Exemption:** there is no concept of paper-wise exemption at Foundation. You must clear all four together.

What the pass rule really means

40% each and 50% overall, in one sitting. So a strong performance in two papers cannot rescue a paper where you score 39. Plan for balance: the objective papers (3 and 4) are where a well-prepared candidate can bank high marks quickly, which lifts the aggregate and cushions the descriptive papers.

The pass rule, worked out in numbers

Both conditions — 40% in every paper and 50% overall — must hold at the same sitting. These three examples show why:

Scores (out of 100)	Aggregate	Result
P1 52 · P2 41 · P3 68 · P4 55	216 / 400 = 54.0%	Pass — all papers >= 40 and aggregate >= 50
P1 62 · P2 38 · P3 70 · P4 60	230 / 400 = 57.5%	Fail — P2 is below 40, despite a strong aggregate
P1 45 · P2 42 · P3 48 · P4 44	179 / 400 = 44.8%	Fail — every paper clears 40 but the aggregate is below 50

The lesson is balance. Two brilliant papers cannot carry one below 40; and a uniform, modest performance across all four still fails if it averages under 50. Aim for a safe 50–60 in every paper rather than a spike in one.

Part 5 · Intermediate — two routes in, six papers

Intermediate is the middle level and the widest gate. You can enter it after clearing Foundation (the Foundation route) or directly, as a graduate, on the strength of your degree (the Direct Entry route). The exam is six papers in two groups, and it is the level where most students first learn to write exam-style answers under time pressure.

Two ways in

Route	Who qualifies
Foundation route	You have passed the Foundation exam and your Class 12 board examination.
Direct Entry route	Commerce graduates / post-graduates with 55%+; non-commerce graduates / post-graduates with 60%+; or those who have cleared CS (Executive) or CMA (Intermediate) of ICSI / ICMAI.

Direct Entry candidates who register in the final year of graduation do so provisionally; the registration is confirmed once the degree mark-sheet with the required marks is submitted. Either way, the eight-month study period before the exam applies.

The six papers

Six papers, 100 marks each, arranged in two groups of three.

Group I

- **Paper 1 — Advanced Accounting** (100 marks).
- **Paper 2 — Corporate and Other Laws** (100 marks).
- **Paper 3 — Taxation**: Section A Income-tax Law (50 marks) and Section B GST (50 marks).

Group II

- **Paper 4 — Cost and Management Accounting** (100 marks).
- **Paper 5 — Auditing and Ethics** (100 marks).
- **Paper 6 — Financial Management and Strategic Management**: Section A Financial Management (50 marks) and Section B Strategic Management (50 marks).

Exam pattern and the pass rule

- **Format:** in every paper, **30% case-study / case-scenario MCQs and 70% descriptive questions**.
- **Negative marking:** none in Intermediate.
- **Pass rule:** you pass a group if, at one sitting, you score a minimum of **40% in each paper of that group** and a minimum of **50% in the aggregate of that group**. You can pass both groups simultaneously, or one group at a time in different sittings.
- **Registration validity:** 5 years from registration, revalidatable once for a further 5 years on a Rs. 400 fee.
- **Registration fee:** Rs. 18,000 for both groups.

How exemptions actually work

This is the rule most students misunderstand. An exemption is not a shortcut you can claim; it is awarded automatically when you meet a threshold, and it has conditions attached.

- If you appear in all the papers of a group and fail one or more, but score **60% or more** in a paper, you are exempted in that paper for the **next three examinations**.
- With the exemption, you still need **40% in each remaining paper** and **50% in the aggregate** (including the exempted paper) to pass the group.
- If you exhaust the three attempts without passing the group, you may continue the exemption, but then you must score **50% in each remaining paper** to pass.
- Exemptions apply at Intermediate and Final — not at Foundation, where no paper-wise exemption exists.

Practical read of the exemption rule

The exemption rewards a strong paper, but the aggregate condition means you cannot ignore the rest of the group. The cleanest strategy is to target 60%+ in the paper you are strongest at, and a safe 50%+ in the others — which secures both the exemption and the group.

The group rule, worked out

A group passes on the same 40%-each and 50%-aggregate test, applied to the three papers of that group:

Group I scores (out of 100)	Aggregate	Result
P1 55 · P2 48 · P3 60	163 / 300 = 54.3%	Group passed — all >= 40, aggregate >= 50
P1 61 · P2 52 · P3 47	160 / 300 = 53.3%	Group passed — even without any 60%+ paper
P1 66 · P2 39 · P3 58	163 / 300 = 54.3%	Group failed — P2 below 40, so the 66 does not save it

Now the exemption in action: if in the third row P1 had scored 66 (>= 60) and you failed the group, P1 is exempted for your next three attempts. You then need 40% in each remaining paper and 50% across the group including the exempted paper. Note the order of events: the exemption only applies once you have *appeared in all the papers* of the group and still failed it.

The Direct Entry route, in depth

If you are a graduate, you may skip Foundation entirely and enter at Intermediate. The requirements are specific and worth stating exactly:

- **Commerce graduates / post-graduates:** minimum **55%** aggregate marks.
- **Non-commerce graduates / post-graduates:** minimum **60%** aggregate marks.
- **Alternatively:** you have passed the Executive level of ICSI (Company Secretary) or the Intermediate level of ICMAI (Cost Accountant).
- If you register in the final year of your degree, your registration is **provisional**; it is confirmed once you submit the degree mark-sheet showing the required marks, normally within six months of the result.
- The same **eight-month study period** applies before you can sit the Intermediate examination.

Direct Entry is the reason a graduate can reach CA without going back to a Foundation exam. It is also a common route for working professionals who decide to add the qualification later in their careers.

Part 6 · One group or both? The attempt strategy

This is the decision that most affects your odds in Intermediate, and the official data answers it clearly. In both 2026 sessions, candidates who attempted a single group passed at a far higher rate than those who attempted both groups together.

Session (2026)	Group I	Group II	Both groups
January	13.96%	15.54%	9.39%
May	10.25%	16.11%	8.47%

A single group has consistently passed at roughly one-and-a-half to nearly twice the rate of both groups together. That is not a small edge — it is the difference between one attempt and two.

How to decide

Your situation	Sensible choice
Full-time student, syllabus mostly covered, strong mocks	Attempt both groups — but only if your mock scores clear 50% in every paper.
Full-time student, one group clearly weaker	Take the stronger group this cycle; target the weaker one next cycle.
Working or studying alongside, limited hours	One group at a time. The three-attempt cycle exists for exactly this.
Direct-entry graduate with a job	One group per attempt, sequenced to your study time.
Repeater who failed one paper last time	Reappear in that group; use any 60%+ paper as an exemption.

The three-attempts-a-year structure is the reason this strategy is now practical. Taking one group in January and the other in May still means you finish the level within a year — without betting everything on a single sitting.

The rule of thumb

Do not attempt both groups on hope. Attempt both only when a closed-book, timed mock of each paper is clearing 50%. If even one paper is short, split the groups — the data says you will be better off.

Part 7 · After Intermediate — the rest of the road

Passing Intermediate is a milestone, not the finish. Between Intermediate and the Final examination sit four compulsory elements: the IT and soft-skills course, two years of practical training, the Self-Paced Online Modules, and the advanced version of the IT and soft-skills course. Miss any one and the Final stays closed. Here is the sequence, in order.

Step 1 · ICITSS — before articleship

The Integrated Course on Information Technology and Soft Skills (ICITSS) is a four-week course made up of the Orientation Course (OC) and Information Technology Training (ITT). It must be completed **before** you commence practical training.

Step 2 · Practical training — two years of articleship

After passing both groups of Intermediate and completing ICITSS, you commence two years of practical training as an articled assistant under a practising Chartered Accountant. You are entitled to 12 leaves in each year. During the last part of the two years, an optional Industrial Training placement of 9 to 12 months is permitted.

Step 3 · Register for Final, and the Self-Paced Online Modules

You register for the Final course after passing both Intermediate groups, and at the same time you register for the four Self-Paced Online Modules. These are self-study modules you qualify at your own pace on ICAI's digital learning campus (lms.icai.org), then test through the SPMT portal. There are four sets:

Set	Paper	Weight	Hours
SET A	Corporate and Economic Laws (mandatory)	100 marks	40
SET B	Strategic Cost and Performance Management (mandatory)	100 marks	40
SET C	Elective — choose 1 of 10 (e.g. Risk Management, Valuation, Forensic Accounting, International Taxation)	100 marks	20
SET D	Multidisciplinary — choose 1 of 4 (Constitution & Advocacy, Psychology & Philosophy, Entrepreneurship, Digital Ecosystem)	100 marks	20

- You qualify a module by scoring a minimum of **50%**. There is no limit on attempts and no negative marking.
- SET A and SET B are mandatory; from SET C you pick one of ten, from SET D one of four.
- The marks are **not** added to your Final marks — the modules are a gate, not a score.
- You must qualify the modules before you can appear in the Final examination.

Step 4 · Advanced ICITSS — after articleship

After completing practical training, you take the Advanced Integrated Course on IT and Soft Skills (Advanced ICITSS) — four weeks of Management and Communication Skills (MCS) plus Advanced IT Training. It must be done before you appear in the Final examination.

Step 5 · The Final — six papers

Group	Papers
Final Group I	Financial Reporting; Advanced Financial Management; Advanced Auditing, Assurance and Professional Ethics
Final Group II	Direct Tax Laws & International Taxation; Indirect Tax Laws; Integrated Business Solutions (a case-study paper with Strategic Management)

The Final follows the same 30% MCQ / 70% descriptive pattern as Intermediate, with no negative marking, and the same 40%-each / 50%-aggregate pass rule. Paper 6, Integrated Business Solutions, is an open-book, entirely case-study paper. The Final is held twice a year.

Eligibility to sit the Final — the full checklist

1. You are registered for the Final course.
2. You have completed practical training at least six months before the first day of the exam month.
3. You have successfully completed Advanced ICITSS.
4. You have qualified all four Self-Paced Online Modules.

The exit route — Business Accounting Associate

If you choose to leave the course before qualifying as a CA, the scheme provides a recognised exit credential: the **Business Accounting Associate (BAA)** certificate. You qualify for it once you have (a) passed both groups of Intermediate, (b) completed practical training, (c) completed Advanced ICITSS, and (d) qualified the Self-Paced Online Modules as applicable. It is a real qualification for the years of work invested, and a useful safety net if life changes course.

Membership

Clear the Final and you apply to ICAI for membership. Only then are you entitled to use the designation “Chartered Accountant” and the letters CA before your name, and to sign the audit and certification work that the licence permits.

Part 8 · Real competition data

ICAI publishes pass percentages for every session, and they are blunt. In the January 2026 Foundation examination, 1,09,694 candidates appeared and 21,099 passed — about one in five. Intermediate is harsher still. Knowing the real numbers is not discouraging; it is the honest reason to prepare differently from the crowd.

Foundation — 2026 sessions

Session	Appeared	Passed	Pass %	Centres
January 2026	1,09,694	21,099	19.23%	566
May 2026	90,217	18,124	20.09%	609

The May 2026 Foundation topper scored 371 out of 400 (92.75%). In the same session the male pass rate was 20.88% and the female pass rate 19.24% — close enough that gender is not the variable that decides this exam. Preparation is.

Intermediate — 2026 sessions, by group

Session	Group	Appeared	Passed	Pass %
January 2026	Group I	1,05,526	14,733	13.96%
January 2026	Group II	69,477	10,798	15.54%
January 2026	Both groups	41,798	3,924	9.39%
May 2026	Group I	91,237	9,350	10.25%
May 2026	Group II	64,381	10,372	16.11%
May 2026	Both groups	33,304	2,820	8.47%

Two patterns jump out. First, **Group II passes at a higher rate than Group I** in every session shown — Group I (Advanced Accounting, Corporate & Other Laws, Taxation) is where the marks are lost. Second, attempting **both groups together roughly halves your chance** compared with a single group: the both-groups rate sits near 8–9% while single groups run 10–16%. That is the single most actionable statistic in this handbook, and Part 6 turns it into a decision.

One caveat worth stating plainly: pass percentages move session to session and depend on difficulty and candidate mix. Treat them as a rough guide to where to spend effort, not as a prediction of your own result. The one factor you fully control is how well prepared you walk in.

How to read a pass percentage without fooling yourself

- **It is per session and per group, not per student.** A 14% Group I figure includes first-timers and repeaters together; it is not your personal chance.
- **It moves with difficulty.** A harder paper in one session lowers the rate for that session only — it says nothing about the next.
- **Compare, don't predict.** The useful comparisons are group versus both-groups, and one session versus another. That is how the one-group edge becomes visible.
- **The controllable variable is preparation.** Everything else in the statistic is fixed for you on the day.

Part 9 · What the whole course costs

The CA course is affordable next to most professional degrees, but the payments arrive at several points, and it helps to see them together. Below are the fees ICAI has published. Some course components — ICITSS, Advanced ICITSS and the Self-Paced Module tests — carry their own charges that ICAI lists separately; verify those on icai.org before budgeting.

One-time course registration fees

Course	Registration fee	Validity	Revalidation
Foundation	Rs. 9,000	4 years (no revalidation)	—
Intermediate	Rs. 18,000	5 years	Once, 5 years, Rs. 400
Final	Rs. 22,000	10 years	Every 10 years, Rs. 500

Per-attempt exam fees (January 2027)

Exam	Indian centre	Kathmandu	Overseas (excl. Kathmandu)
Foundation	Rs. 1,500	Rs. 2,200	US$ 325
Intermediate — one group	Rs. 1,500	Rs. 2,200	US$ 325
Intermediate — both groups	Rs. 2,700	Rs. 3,400	US$ 500

Other charges to know about

- **Late exam-form fee:** Rs. 600 (India / Kathmandu) or US$ 10 (overseas) if you miss the free deadline.
- **Study material re-order** (if you already took the old material and convert): Rs. 500 (Foundation), Rs. 1,000 (Intermediate), Rs. 1,000 (Final).
- **ICITSS and Advanced ICITSS:** four-week courses with their own fees — check the current amount on icai.org.
- **Self-Paced Online Modules:** no separate registration fee; the module tests are booked through the SPMT portal.

A rough total to plan for

Registration alone (Foundation + Intermediate + Final) is Rs. 49,000, spread across the years. Add exam fees for each attempt you take, the two ICITSS courses, and any coaching you choose. The point is not that CA is expensive — it is that the costs are staged, so budget per year, not all at once.

Where the money goes, stage by stage

Stage	What you pay	Amount
Start of course	Foundation registration	Rs. 9,000
Each Foundation attempt	Foundation exam fee	Rs. 1,500
After Foundation	Intermediate registration	Rs. 18,000
Each Intermediate attempt	One group / both groups	Rs. 1,500 / Rs. 2,700
Before articleship	ICITSS (4 weeks)	Fee on ICAI website
After both Inter groups	Final registration	Rs. 22,000
After articleship	Advanced ICITSS (4 weeks)	Fee on ICAI website
Before Final	Self-Paced Module tests	Booked on the SPMT portal

Two things follow from this. First, the big registration payments are one-time, so plan them at the stage you reach them rather than all at once. Second, the recurring cost is the per-attempt exam fee — which is one more reason to attempt a group you are genuinely ready for rather than to sit an unprepared paper.

Part 10 · How to use ICAI's own study material

The most under-used resource in the CA course is ICAI's own material — which is also the material the papers are set from. Coaching can help, but nothing replaces the official study material, revision papers and mock tests. Used properly, they are a complete preparation system.

The four official resources, and what each is for

Resource	What it is	How to use it
Study Material (SM)	ICAI's full syllabus text, module by module.	First pass — build the concepts and the base notes.
Revision Test Papers (RTP)	Practice papers released before each exam session.	Revision phase — test recall on the full syllabus.
Mock Test Papers (MTP)	Full-length, exam-style papers with suggested answers.	Timed, closed-book practice in exam conditions.
Past question papers + Suggested Answers	Real papers from previous sessions with model answers.	Pattern study — learn how ICAI expects answers to be structured.

ICAI also runs live virtual classes for Foundation students, a “Success at CA Exam” series and mock-test series ahead of sessions. These appear on icai.org under the Board of Studies, and they are worth watching for because they are free and syllabus-accurate.

The order that works

1. Read the Study Material module for a topic, and make your own one-page summary as you go — not a copy, a compression.
2. Solve the questions at the end of each module immediately. Reading without solving is the most common wasted month in the course.
3. Once the syllabus is done, move to RTPs to test recall across topics.
4. Then do MTPs and past papers under exam conditions — timed, closed-book, in the afternoon like the real paper.
5. Keep one error register across all of it. Before the exam, revise from your summaries and your error register, not the whole syllabus again.

Why past papers matter more than people think

ICAI's papers are set from its own material, and the style of answer — workings shown, formats followed, provisions quoted — is consistent. Reading suggested answers teaches you the shape of a scoring answer, which is a skill distinct from knowing the content.

Part 11 · Your 8-week plan to January 2027

This plan assumes you fill the exam form in early November and have roughly eight weeks before the first paper. It is built around the exam sequence, not around comfort: the papers that come first get their revision earliest. If you are attempting a single Intermediate group, compress the same structure into fewer subjects and go deeper.

The week-by-week spine

Week	Dates (2026–27)	Focus
1	16–22 Nov	Register (form + fee). Write a diagnostic/previous-year paper cold. List your three weakest topics per subject.
2	23–29 Nov	First full pass of the earliest papers (Foundation P1/P2 or Inter P1–P3). Build one-page summary sheets as you go.
3	30 Nov–6 Dec	Finish the first pass. Start daily problem practice in the numerical papers (Quant/Accounting/Cost).
4	7–13 Dec	First mock per subject, timed and closed-book. Log every error in a single error register.
5	14–20 Dec	Attack the error register. Re-read only the topics that produced mistakes. Second pass of law/theory papers.
6	21–27 Dec	Second mock per subject. Begin written-answer practice — presentation, workings, formats.
7	28 Dec–3 Jan	Full mocks in exam order and exam timings (2 PM start). Revise summary sheets only — no new material.
8	4–11 Jan	Taper. Light revision, sleep discipline, exam-day logistics. Sit the papers.

How to actually study each week

- **Study in exam order.** The first paper you sit is the one you should have solid first. Accounting leads Foundation; Advanced Accounting leads Intermediate. Do not leave them to the end.
- **One pass, then problems.** Reading the study material twice does not equal solving. The numerical papers are passed with solved questions, not underlined text.
- **Keep one error register.** Every wrong answer in a mock goes into one notebook, with the reason. This single habit is worth more than any extra book.
- **Write answers by hand.** The descriptive papers are marked on presentation — workings shown, formats correct, headings clear. Practise this, not just mental recall.

Time-budget reality

Eight weeks is enough for a focused candidate who has done some groundwork, and tight for one starting cold. Be honest about which you are. If you have not yet covered the syllabus, use this cycle to clear the papers you can genuinely finish and aim the rest at May 2027 — that is exactly what the three-attempts-a-year structure is for.

Starting from scratch? Plan the next cycle

If you are only beginning now, the January 2027 registration cut-offs have passed. That is not a problem — it just moves your target. Use the study-period rules to pick your attempt:

If you register by	Foundation: earliest attempt	Intermediate: earliest attempt
1 January 2027	May 2027	September 2027
1 May 2027	September 2027	— (register earlier for Sep)

The rule behind the table: you must be registered four months before the Foundation exam month and eight months before the Intermediate exam month. Registering early costs you nothing and protects your eligibility — the most common cause of a missed attempt is registering too late, not studying too little.

Part 12 · Subject playbooks

Short, specific tactics for each paper. The pattern is the same throughout: secure the scoring topics first, then spend your remaining time on the difficult ones.

Foundation

Paper 1 · Accounting

- Master the accounting process (journal, ledger, trial balance, rectification) — it underpins everything and appears in most questions.
- Final accounts of sole proprietors and partnership accounts (admission, retirement, goodwill) are high-frequency, high-mark areas.
- Company accounts — issue, forfeiture and re-issue of shares — are formulaic once practised; secure them early.

Paper 2 · Business Laws

- Learn the Contract Act and Sale of Goods Act definitions precisely — marks come from correct legal language, not paraphrase.
- Companies Act topics (incorporation, MOA/AOA, indoor management) are predictable; prepare them as a block.
- Practise answering in the structure: provision -> application to facts -> conclusion.

Paper 3 · Quantitative Aptitude (objective)

- Because there is 0.25 negative marking, do not guess blindly. Attempt what you know; skip what you do not.
- Statistics and mathematics of finance are the most reliably scoring parts — drill them for speed.
- Logical reasoning rewards timed practice more than study; do a set daily.

Paper 4 · Business Economics (objective)

- Demand, supply and elasticity, and cost concepts, carry the most questions — own them.
- Micro topics (markets, price determination) tend to be cleaner than macro; bank them first.
- Same negative-marking discipline as Paper 3: answer with intent, not hope.

Intermediate

Group I — the harder group, historically

- **Advanced Accounting:** consolidate the accounting standards and company-accounts chapters; they carry disproportionate marks.
- **Corporate and Other Laws:** treat it like Foundation Business Laws but wider — precise provisions win marks.
- **Taxation:** Income-tax and GST are each 50 marks. Practise computation formats — the presentation earns marks as much as the figure.

Group II — the higher pass-rate group

- **Cost and Management Accounting:** highly scoring if you drill the standard problems; a marks-banker.
- **Auditing and Ethics:** answer in points with correct terminology; length is less important than accuracy.
- **FM and Strategic Management:** Financial Management (50) rewards practice; Strategic Management (50) rewards structured, application-based answers.

The 30% MCQ advantage

In Intermediate every paper opens with 30% case-study MCQs and there is no negative marking on them. These are the fastest, safest marks in the paper — read them carefully and answer all of them before you start the descriptive part.

Part 13 · Exam-day playbook

ICAI runs these exams in offline, centre-based mode, in the afternoon. The rules are strict and uniform. Get the logistics right and you free your mind for the paper.

What to carry, and what is banned

Bring to the centre:

- A printed copy of your **admit card** (download from eservices.icai.org; no physical admit card is posted to you).
- An **original, valid photo ID** — Aadhaar, PAN, voter ID, passport or driving licence.
- A **blue or black ballpoint pen**.
- Only a **battery-operated portable calculator** is allowed. **Scientific calculators are not permitted.**

Leave outside the hall:

- Books, notes, study material of any kind.
- Electronic gadgets and metal items.
- Scientific or programmable calculators.

Timing on the day

Point	Detail
Centre entry	From about 1:15 PM
Advance reading time	1:45–2:00 PM for all papers except Foundation Papers 3 & 4
Paper begins	2:00 PM
Late entry	Permitted up to 15 minutes after the paper starts
Early exit	Not permitted — you cannot leave until the paper concludes

How to run the three hours

1. In the advance reading time, scan the whole paper and mark the questions you can answer best.
2. Answer the questions you know well first — it banks marks and settles nerves.
3. For computation papers, show every working; marks are awarded for method as well as the final figure.
4. In Intermediate, clear the 30% MCQs early — no negative marking, so attempt all of them.
5. Reserve the last 10 minutes to check that every attempted question is numbered and legible.

The night before

Sleep. Confirm your centre's exact address and travel time, keep your admit card and ID in one place, and stop studying new topics after mid-evening. The candidate who arrives rested and calm outperforms the one who revised until 2 AM — every session.

Part 14 · After CA — where the qualification takes you

The reason to sit through all of this is the career on the other side. A Chartered Accountant qualification opens several distinct paths, and you choose between them after membership, not before. Here is the map, honestly drawn.

The main paths

- **Practice:** start or join a CA firm — audit, tax, advisory and certification work. This is the route to signing authority and, eventually, your own practice.
- **Industry / corporate:** finance and controllership roles inside companies — accounting, FP&A, internal audit, treasury, compliance, and CFO-track positions over time.
- **Consulting and advisory:** transaction advisory, risk, forensic accounting, valuation and similar specialist work, often with larger firms.
- **Public sector and regulation:** roles with regulators, public-sector undertakings and statutory bodies.
- **Entrepreneurship:** many CAs build their own practices, or move into business and finance leadership with the licence as a foundation.

ICAI's role in placements

ICAI runs a campus placement programme for newly qualified members, and publishes its list of recruiters and placement updates on its website. If you want current, specific figures on offers and recruiters, ICAI's own placement pages are the authoritative source — treat any salary number you see on social media with caution unless it traces back there.

A note on the numbers you will hear

You will see dramatic salary claims about “CA packages” online. Those figures vary enormously by firm, city, specialisation and year, and are not something this handbook will invent. Build the qualification first; the specific numbers are a decision you make later, with real offers in hand.

Part 15 · Myths versus reality

A lot of what circulates about CA is outdated or simply wrong, and it shapes decisions badly. Here are seven beliefs worth discarding, each corrected against ICAI's own rules and data.

The myth	The reality
“The pass rate is about 2% — it is nearly impossible.”	Foundation passed at about 19–20% in the 2026 sessions, and single Intermediate groups at 10–16%. Demanding, not impossible.
“You must join coaching to pass.”	Coaching can help, but ICAI provides study material, RTPs, MTPs, past papers with suggested answers, and live virtual classes — free and syllabus-accurate.
“Articleship is three years.”	It is two years under the current scheme.
“Exams are only in May and November.”	Foundation and Intermediate now run three times a year — January, May and September. Only the Final is twice a year.
“You can get exemptions at Foundation.”	No. There is no paper-wise exemption at Foundation. Exemptions apply at Intermediate and Final.
“There is negative marking in every paper.”	Negative marking (0.25) applies only to the Foundation objective papers. Intermediate and Final have none.
“You can sit the Final as soon as you clear Intermediate.”	No — you must also complete ICITSS, two years of practical training, Advanced ICITSS and all four Self-Paced Online Modules.

The common thread in every myth is a version of the course that no longer exists. Checking the rule at icai.org, not a coaching WhatsApp group, is the habit that keeps you accurate.

Part 16 · FAQ, quick-reference and links

Frequently asked questions

Can I register for Foundation while still in Class 11? Yes. You may register for the Foundation course after passing Class 10. You can sit the Foundation exam only after you have appeared in your Class 12 board examination and completed a four-month study period from registration.

How many times a year are the exams held now? Foundation and Intermediate are held three times a year — January, May and September. The Final is held twice a year.

Is there negative marking? Yes, but only in the Foundation objective papers (Papers 3 and 4), where 0.25 mark is deducted per wrong answer. Intermediate and Final have no negative marking.

What is the pass mark? 40% in each paper and 50% in the aggregate, at one sitting — at every level. At Intermediate and Final you may pass a group on its own.

Do exemptions exist at Foundation? No. There is no paper-wise exemption at Foundation. Exemptions (at 60%+ in a paper) apply at Intermediate and Final.

How long is my registration valid? Foundation: 4 years from the first eligible attempt, with no revalidation. Intermediate: 5 years, revalidatable once for a further 5 years (Rs. 400). Final: 10 years, revalidatable every 10 years (Rs. 500).

Can I answer in Hindi? Yes — Foundation and Intermediate candidates may opt for English or Hindi. Note that Foundation Papers 3 and 4 have English-medium OMR sheets only.

What happens if I leave the course midway? The scheme provides the Business Accounting Associate (BAA) certificate on meeting the criteria — passing both Intermediate groups, completing practical training, Advanced ICITSS and the Self-Paced Online Modules as applicable.

Do I need to send a hard copy of the exam form? No. The exam form is submitted online through the SSP; you keep a copy of the barcoded form for your records.

Where do I download the admit card? From eservices.icai.org, generally about 14 days before the exam. No physical admit card is sent.

Quick-reference card

Key fact	January 2027
Foundation exam dates	3, 5, 7, 9 January 2027
Intermediate Group I	2, 4, 6 January 2027
Intermediate Group II	8, 10, 12 January 2027
Exam form opens	3 November 2026
Form deadline (no late fee)	16 November 2026
Form deadline (late fee)	19 November 2026
Correction window	20–22 November 2026
Exam fee — Foundation / Inter one group	Rs. 1,500
Exam fee — Inter both groups	Rs. 2,700
Exam timing	2:00 PM IST (Foundation Papers 3 & 4 end at 4:00 PM)
Exam centres	207 cities in India + Bahrain, Dubai, Kathmandu

Final checklist before you apply

- Course registration done, and the study-period cut-off met (Foundation: 1 Sep 2026; Intermediate: 1 May 2026).
- Class 12 mark-sheet / admit card uploaded in SSP (Foundation candidates).
- SSP login working; photo and signature uploaded and of acceptable quality.
- Exam form filled and fee paid, with the barcoded form PDF saved.
- Medium (English/Hindi) and exam city checked before the correction window closes.
- Admit card downloaded about two weeks before the exam.
- Original photo ID ready for exam day.

Official links

- **ICAI main site:** icai.org
- **Self Service Portal (registration, exam form, admit card):** eservices.icai.org
- **Board of Studies knowledge portal and study material:** icai.org (New Scheme of Education and Training)
- **Self-Paced Online Modules learning campus:** lms.icai.org
- **Self-Paced Module Test portal:** spmt.icai.org
- **Results:** icai.nic.in / caresults.icai.org

This handbook is an independent study aid. Always confirm dates, fees and rules at icai.org before acting. © digitalkartai.shop · January 2027 Edition.